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Universal session protocol

Abstract

The invention comprises a universal session protocol configured to initiate, authenticate, and manage the session of an application data stream. The universal session protocol governs the interaction between sending applications and sending agents as well as receiving applications and receiving agents to establish authenticated data streams between applications or systems.

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Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATION (1) The present application is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/219,386, filed Jul. 7, 2023, which will issue as U.S. Pat. No. 11,895,198 on Feb. 6, 2024, which claims priority to and the benefit of U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 63/420,417, filed Oct. 28, 2022, the contents of which are incorporated herein by reference and made a part hereof.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(1) The present invention generally relates to the field of data transmission through any form of data stream between a sending and receiving agent on behalf of a sending and receiving application, respectively, for the sake of initiating, authenticating, and managing a data stream to be used for the purpose of transmitting data between applications.

(2) The current paradigm for stream session establishment puts the responsibility for initiation, authentication, and management on an application itself, rather than a dedicated procedure executed by agents that abstracts that responsibility away from the application. Two consequences of this design include (1) that applications are processing client data before having established the identity of the client, leaving any errors in program design exposed to anonymous exploitation, and (2) there is no universal standardized method of authenticating a session, so any new applications are left to reinvent the process. This is a significant vulnerability in computing because even the most secure applications must process unauthenticated user data in order to determine (1) whether authentication is necessary, (2) whether there is authentication information in the stream, and (3) whether the user would be authorized to process data in the application even if authenticated.

(3) Vulnerabilities are exposed because applications establish data streams directly with the requesting client and begin processing application data immediately. The bytes of application data may or may not contain a malicious payload, and they may or may not contain an identity. In order for the application to determine whether an identity needs to be or can be established, it necessarily must process the received application data so that it can be analyzed for intent and identity information. Because the application data is processed, if the application data is a malicious payload, it will also be processed. If the payload was successful at targeting a vulnerability, the system is compromised.

(4) In order to overcome the shortcoming of these prior network protocols, the present invention uses the data stream to examine strictly structured data from the requesting client to first determine whether authentication is necessary, and then to complete authentication if needed. Applications only have access to the data stream after an identity is established by the protocol, meaning that only data from known users will be processed on the system and all data that is processed will be associated with an identity.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(5) In view of the above, a novel protocol configured to authenticate a data stream from a sending application prior to providing accesses to the application layer of the receiving application is provided herein. The objective of the inventive protocol is to process all session management needs for an application, using any type of data stream. As a requirement of the inventive protocol, applications would only have access to data streams after the protocol has determined that the client is authorized to access the application. Further, if authorization is not granted by the protocol, the protocol ensures that clients are not able to transmit data into the application.

(6) To accomplish this objective, the protocol creates an additional discrete process that is completed before any application, using an agent component that is granted access to that stream;

applications will no longer listen directly for incoming requests and client requests will instead be curated for the application by the protocol. Restricting access to data streams is possible due to rules governing what resources are in scope for the running process to access. Until the protocol completes, the data stream will not be in scope for the application, so no data may be transmitted or received across the stream into the application.

(7) In one aspect, the protocol comprises a method of processing data when an application's agent builds and transmits a data stream comprising the steps of: client application sending an initialization request from a sending agent, receiving agent for a server application listening for the initialization request, the applications building the data stream, the second application checking for an authentication requirement, if authentication is required, the sending agent sends authentication credentials back to the receiving agent, and if authenticated successfully at the receiving agent, the data stream is allowed to enter the application layer of the receiving application.

(8) It should be recognized by one of skill in the art that the term "computer" includes but is not limited to devices that communicate across a connected network such as servers, personal computers, smart phones, and tablets.

(9) The methods, systems, apparatuses are set forth in part in the description which follows, and in part will be obvious from the description, or can be learned by practice of the methods, apparatuses, and systems. The advantages of the methods, apparatuses, and systems will be realized and attained by means of the elements and combinations particularly pointed out in the appended claims. It is understood that both the foregoing general description and the following detailed description are exemplary and explanatory only and are not restrictive of the methods, apparatuses, and systems, as claimed.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) In the accompanying figures, like elements are identified by like reference numerals among the several preferred embodiments of the present invention.

(2) FIG. 1 illustrates a prior art data stream session management.

(3) FIG. 2 illustrates an embodiment of inventive data stream session management protocol.

(4) FIG. 3 illustrates a server determining that the requested application does not require authentication, and sending a message for the client to complete the connection.

(5) FIG. 4 illustrates a server determining that the requested application requires authentication, and coordinating and completing authentication.

(6) FIG. 5 illustrates authentication by proxy.

(7) FIG. 6 illustrates authentication protocol negotiation failure.

(8) FIG. 7 illustrates authentication failure.

(9) FIG. 8 illustrates application not hosted error.

(10) FIG. 9 illustrates invalid data structure error.

(11) FIG. 10 illustrates an initialize message.

(12) FIG. 11 illustrates a connect message.

(13) FIG. 12 illustrates an authenticate message.

(14) FIG. 13 illustrates a token message.

(15) FIG. 14 illustrates an error message.

(16) Other aspects and advantages of the present invention will become apparent upon consideration of the following detailed description, wherein similar structures have similar reference numerals.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF THE PREFERRED EMBODIMENTS

(17) The foregoing and other features and advantages of the invention will become more apparent

from the following detailed description of an exemplary embodiment, read in conjunction with the accompanying drawings. The detailed description and drawings are merely illustrative of the invention rather than limiting, the scope of the invention being defined by the appended claims and equivalents thereof.

(18) FIG. 1 represents a generalized view of the prior art for establishing data stream connections and processing user data. In the prior art protocol illustrated, a client first attempts to establish a stream with the server application **106**. If the connection is successful, the server immediately begins processing user data **112**. The server must process user data in order to determine whether an identity is required for the particular request being processed **112**, whether an identity is present in the data, and whether that identity will be authorized for subsequent operations. Because the data is processed before an identity is established, the full content of the user data is not associated with an identity. It is this processing prior to authentication that grants access to vulnerabilities for exploitation anonymously.

(19) FIG. 2, by comparison, shows the inventive protocol takes active steps to identify and authenticate a data stream prior to data being processed by server. The protocol ensures application data is processed after an identity is established **214**, **216**, **218**, and because of this, it will also ensure that all subsequent data can be associated with a specific identity. Further shown in FIG. 2, the application client builds the data stream and the client sends an initialization request. If the remote system is not listening, the connection will time out **208**. If the remote system is listening, the application server builds the data stream **210**, but the listening system will analyze the data stream to see if authentication is required **214** for this particular data stream or application. If authentication is not required, the data stream application layer data is processed by the receiving system **212**. If authentication is required **212**, an authentication request will be sent back to the sending system to provide appropriate authentication credentials **214**. If successful, the receiving system will authenticate the credentials and allow access to process application layer data **218**. If authentication is not successful, the receiving system will request additional authentication or reject the data stream **216**, **214**.

(20) The protocol employs a number of safeguards in the authentication process. A first safeguard is mechanical and takes advantage of the physical limitations for resource access guaranteed by computer systems. A resource is said to be available within a scope if the commands within the executing segment of code can use or manipulate the resource or access its memory addresses. Because processes relying on the protocol, such as the target server application, do not have a data stream resource or address assigned to the data stream resource until after the protocol has fully processed and completed, there is a guarantee that data from unauthenticated sources will not be processed by the target application.

(21) A second safeguard is social and relies on the association of an identity with data that is being processed by the target server application. Because computers can aggregate resources and information into abstract structures, the information that is provided by protocol is not limited to the data stream itself. When authentication is complete, the identity of the remote user will be represented in the form of a secure string of bytes known as a token. The resource given to the receiving application will include the identity token alongside the data stream so that each transmission may be recorded with the identity for forensic investigation. This provides the ability to identify and address malicious activity directly associated with the identity token.

(22) FIG. 3 expands on the authentication process shown in FIG. 2 and demonstrates a connection for a target server application that does not require authentication. Because many applications hosted on the internet are intended for general public use, there must be a mechanism for protocol to complete connections without establishing an identity first. As further shown in the flow chart and steps of FIG. 3: 1. **302** Client agent sends a message to the server agent stating the intention to connect. 2. **304** Server agent determines that it is hosting the requested application. 3. **306** Server agent determines that the requested application does not require authentication. 4. **308** Server agent

sends a message to the client agent stating that the connection may be completed. 5. Client and server agents both return a data stream resource or address to a data stream resource to client and server application.

(23) FIG. 4 expands on the authentication process shown in FIG. 2 and demonstrates the process for a target server application that requires authentication. As further shown in the flow chart and steps of FIG. 4: 1. Client agent sends a message to the server agent stating the intention to connect **402**. 2. Server agent determines that it is hosting the requested application **404**. 3. Server agent determines that the requested applications require authentication **406**. 4. Server agent determines that the client has not provided valid identity tokens **408**. 5. Server agent negotiates a commonly shared authentication protocol **410**. 6. Server agent sends a message to the client stating that authentication must be completed **412**. 7. Client agent and server agent complete authentication **414**. 8. Server agent sends a message containing the client's identity token **416**. 9. Client agent sends a message to the server stating the intention to connect, this time including identity tokens received in step 7 **418**. 10. Server agent determines that it is hosting the requested application **420**. 11. Server agent determines that the requested applications require authentication **422**. 12. Server agent determines that the client provided valid identity tokens **424**. 13. Server agent sends a message to the client agent stating that the connection may be completed **426**. 14. Client and server agents both return a data stream resource or address to a data stream resource to client and server applications.

(24) Because the process demonstrated in FIG. 4 is essentially the same process executed twice, beginning again on step eight but with different identity tokens, additional scenarios are possible that involve procuring and storing or transferring identity tokens.

(25) FIG. 5 demonstrates another aspect of the protocol that is authentication by proxy. The process of FIG. 4 is completed by two different clients. The proxy client completes step one through eight **502-516** as described for FIG. 4, transfers the token to a tertiary client **518**, and the tertiary client completes steps nine through thirteen **520-528** as described for FIG. 4.

(26) FIG. 6 demonstrates failure to negotiate a mutually supported authentication protocol. In this case, the server agent is unable to find an authentication protocol supported by both the server and the client **610** using a list of supported protocols as provided in the initialize message and a list of protocols known to the server agent to be supported by the server application. An error message is sent as a response **612**.

(27) FIG. 7 demonstrates an authentication failure. In this case, the authentication protocol is successfully negotiated **710**, but the client fails at authentication according to the selected protocol **714**.

(28) FIG. 8 demonstrates a case when the sending agent is attempting to establish a connection to an application that is not hosted by the receiving agent **804** and the receiving agent replies with an error message **806**.

(29) FIG. 9 demonstrates validation of message data structure. In this case, the sender may be the sending or receiving agent and the recipient may be the sending or receiving agent. The recipient determines that the message data structure is invalid **904** and replies with an error message **906**.

(30) FIG. 10 demonstrates the initialization message. One embodiment sends a message from client to server, and it may comprise the following data for these purposes: message **1002** "initialize" Informs the server that the client intends to connect authentication-["<protocol>", "<protocol>"] **1004** An array of protocol names identifying which authentication protocols the client is capable of. streams **1006** An array of sets of data describing the desired target server application and the identity of the client. application **1008** "<application>" The name of the target server application. token **1010** "<token>" An identity token formatted as a byte string for authentication specific to the associated application.

(31) FIG. 11 demonstrates the connect message. The protocol sends this message from server to client, sends one connect message per application, and sends each over a unique data stream to

ensure that each stream is used for the same purpose by client and server. The message comprises the following data for these purposes: message **1102** “connect” Instructs the client to complete the data stream connection for the client application application **1104** “<application>” The name of the target server application for a which a connection is being established.

(32) FIG. **12** demonstrates the authenticate message. The protocol sends this message from server to client, and it contains the following data for these purposes: message **1202** “authenticate” Informs the client to complete an authentication process protocol **1204** “<protocol>” The name of the protocol that client and server will use to complete authentication.

(33) FIG. **13** demonstrates the token message. The protocol sends this message from server to client, and it contains the following data for these purposes: message **1302** “token” Informs the client that authentication was successful and provides a valid identity token for each application requested. streams **1304** An array of sets of data describing the target server application and the identity token to be used by the client for that application. application **1306** “<application>” The name of the target application for which the associated token is to be used token **1308** “<token>” An identity token formatted as a byte string

(34) FIG. **14** demonstrates the error message, and it contains the following data for these purposes: message **1402** “error” Informs the receiving system that an error has occurred error **1404** Human readable description of the error

(35) Those of ordinary skill in the art will understand and appreciate the aforementioned description of the invention has been made with reference to a certain exemplary embodiment of the invention, which describe a data stream authentication protocol and method of use. Those of skill in the art will understand that obvious variations in construction, material, dimensions or properties may be made without departing from the scope of the invention which is intended to be limited only by the claims appended hereto.

Claims

1. A method of transmitting data through a data stream between a sending application having a sending agent and a receiving application having a receiving agent comprising the steps of: the sending agent sending a message to the receiving agent stating an intention to establish a data stream, specifying the receiving application as a target application, and the sending agent enumerating authentication protocols supported by the sending agent, wherein the message includes either an invalid identity token or is missing an identity token; the receiving agent determining that the target application is the application served by the receiving agent; the receiving agent determining that the application data stream requires authentication; the receiving agent determining that there is an invalid identity token or missing identity token; the receiving agent determining an authentication protocol that is mutually supported by the receiving agent and the sending agent; the receiving agent sending an authentication requirement message to sending agent, indicating the authentication protocol to be used to establish sending agent identity; the sending agent adds invalid or missing authentication credentials to the data stream using the authentication protocol; the receiving agent rejecting the credentials using the authentication protocol; and the sending agent and receiving agent aborting the connection attempt.
2. The method of transmitting data through a data stream of claim 1 wherein the steps of the sending agent sending a message to the receiving agent stating the intention to connect, specifying the receiving application as the target application, and the sending agent enumerating authentication protocols supported by the sending agent further comprises the step of initiating a connection to the receiving agent.
3. The method of transmitting data through a data stream of claim 2 wherein the steps of the receiving agent determining that the specified target application is the application served by the receiving agent, the receiving agent determining that the application data stream requires

authentication, the receiving agent determining that the identity token provided by the sending agent is invalid or missing, and receiving agent selecting a mutually supported authentication protocol according to what is enumerated by the sending agent and supported by the receiving agent comprise the steps of authentication protocol negotiation.

4. The method of transmitting data through a data stream of claim 3 wherein the steps of the receiving agent sending a message to the sending agent indicating the negotiated authentication protocol and the requirement to authenticate comprise the steps of initiating authentication.

5. The method of transmitting data through a data stream of claim 4, the sending agent adding invalid or missing authentication credentials to the data stream according to the negotiated authentication protocol, and the receiving agent determining that the credentials are invalid or missing according to the negotiated authentication protocol comprise the steps of authentication failure.
